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App Watch

Spuul: The streaming app with an amazing library

If Bollywood flicks or regional movies interest you, this is the must have app on your tablet.

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Not many apps can do what Spuul can do, but then again, this is not surprising considering the fact that video streaming apps are becoming rather popular. People want to watch a movie on their iPad when on the move or when tucked inside the blanket a cold and lazy winter day, but cannot be bothered to transfer one from their PC most of the time! This is where an app like Spuul can come in quite handy, as long as you are a fan of Bollywood movies.

Interface

The carousel switching between the latest and top movies is the biggest visual pull on the main screen. Below that are various sub-categories, with horizontal scrolling.

For each movie listed on the home screen, there is the accompanying thumbnail image. Without saying so much, the different sub-categories and the listings under each do give you a fairly good idea of the massive library of movies.

Tap on any movie thumbnail, and you go to the details page. A big image on the top of the page, followed by the storyline and the details of the movie, the option to watch the movie or watch the trailer and the ability to share this on social networks - Facebook and Twitter.

Library & Streaming

Quite a few of the streaming apps have flattered to deceive. Mostly because of the poor quality of video that ultimately makes it to your tablet or smartphone. There is no doubt that we have had some excellent performers in starsports.com and Tata Sky's Everywhere TV app, but equally, Dish Online and Ditto TV have disappointed. That was the root cause of the mistrust with which we approached this app. However, I feel happy to report that Spuul adds to the list with Star Sports and Everywhere TV, as one that offers quality streaming. We tested this on a 2Mbps broadband connection, an 8Mbps connection and also on 3G - which offers extremely varied speeds and connectivity strength as you move along. All through,

the streaming experience was smooth. However, since this is streamed content, you cannot jump too far ahead in the timeline at any given point of time, with only the 8 Mbps plan offering a bigger headroom. On the iPad's Retina Display, every movie looked crisp and vivid, irrespective of the brightness level. But, the best part is the consistency of the content quality, across all movies and TV shows.

The library itself is quite wide, with a lot of the recent Bollywood flicks already available - the likes of D-Day and Once Upon A Time In Mumbai Dobaara available. There is an imposing list of movies, including some older ones as well.

We keep mentioning Bollywood flicks, but Spuul also has a fairly good range of regional language movies, including Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Punjabi. Since I am not well versed with those languages, I can only talk about the numbers that I see. TV shows is something that still needs a lot of work - that library is not big enough, and at first glance, looks haphazardly put together. Clearly the focus is on movies.

Subscription

There are quite a few free to watch movies available on Spuul, to get you started. However, the real fun is with the premium subscription packages. One option asks you to pay Rs 270 per month, which allows access to all free and premium movies. The second package is the annual option for the same, costing Rs 2700 per year. However, these subscriptions do not include what Spuul calls as "Specials", and you may have to pay additionally for those later.

Download or Not?

If you are a huge fan of Bollywood movies, this is one app that you must have on your iPhone or iPad or any Android device. The free service lets you browse and watch a selection of movies, while the premium subscriptions remove in-app advertising and let you access the better movie collection. The library is massive for movies, but TV shows still need some improvement. Streaming quality on Wi-Fi and 3G is smooth, as long as you are getting good coverage. The redesigned UI is a lot smoother to use than before. 



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